duty to shield Paulette and Rose from danger. Léa descended the slope to the *chai*, the barrel and aging hall, where at the end of every day, she guided the donkey pulling the wooden cart loaded with grapes. She never entered, always leaving the cart outside for Édouard to bring in. The pale blue wooden doors stood open, flanking the stone walls like shutters. Hearing voices, she hesitated, then took a few cautious steps, inhaling the earthy headiness from the grapes fermenting inside.

"Herr LeBlanc, you test my patience." A man's granite voice echoed off the domed ceiling. "Have my orders not been clear?"

"But last year—"

"It's not your business to remind me of what happened last year."

"My family can't survive if we aren't allowed to make wine."

"And our army can't win without fuel and oil. Your family made it through this year."

Léa positioned herself behind one of the tall concrete vats. She counted six fermentation vats, each with a large stainless-steel plaque and spigot on the front. On the plaque on the vat opposite, she glimpsed the blurry reflection of a gray uniform, black boots and SS runes.

"That's because I sold off the previous year's wine. But if you again requisition all my production, I won't have anything more to sell."

The man's reflection disappeared from her view. "Winter is coming. I must supply the solvents and anti-freeze the army requires. All production will be distilled into fuel and industrial alcohol. Now, open the doors on these vats."

"Why? The fermentation is proceeding. Your fuel will be ready in another week," Édouard said, a tinge of panic in his voice.

"I order you to open the doors on these vats."

"Yes, Weinführer Brucker."

Léa crept to an alcove off to the side so she wouldn't be seen. Since this was the first time she'd been inside the cave, she couldn't quite figure out what was happening, other than the distinct splash of liquid being poured into the vats.

After some time, silence returned. Léa left the alcove, inching her way back to the vat.

"That should take care of any plans you have to siphon off wine." A sharp click of boot heels sent a shudder through her. "I'll be back at the end